Going Through Mom's Statements and Mail: Things to Notice and Mark for a Professional

Fifteen everyday things to notice and write down as you sort the paperwork, with no interpreting.

You're going through Mom's statements and her mail, some of it for the first time, and you're not sure what you're looking for. This guide names fifteen things worth noticing in the mail, on the statements, among her other papers and in what people tell you and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What an item means for Mom's application is a question for your Medicaid planner or another professional who knows her state, and the notes you keep are what make that conversation useful. The things to look for follow lists published by the federal long-term care site, USA.gov, the National Institute on Aging and the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau; the wording about what to write down is ours.

In the mail

1 Anything from the Medicaid agency [1]

NOTICE Envelopes from the state or county office that handles Medicaid. The program may go by a different name in Mom's state.

WRITE DOWN The office, the date on the letter, and where the letter is now. Keep these on top of the pile.

2 Letters that ask for something

NOTICE Any letter that asks for a document, a signature, a reply or a call back.

WRITE DOWN Who sent it, the date on it, what it asks for in its own words, and any reply date printed on it. Copy what it says; don't work anything out.

3 A case or application number

NOTICE A number printed on the agency's letters, or given to you when something was submitted.

WRITE DOWN The number and the letter it came from, at the top of your log. Leave it out of texts, emails and anything you paste into an AI tool.

4 Benefit and income letters [2] [3]

NOTICE Letters about Social Security, a pension, veterans benefits or another regular payment, for Mom and for her spouse if she is married.

WRITE DOWN Who pays it, how often, and the amount as the letter states it.

5 Insurance mail [4]

NOTICE Premium notices and statements for health coverage, life insurance or long-term care insurance.

WRITE DOWN The company, the kind of policy, and where the policy itself is kept.

On the statements

6 The dates each statement covers [3]

NOTICE The first and last date printed on each bank, investment and retirement statement, and the months with no statement in the folder.

WRITE DOWN For each account, the months you have and the months you don't, and whether the statements can be reached online. How far back they need to go is a question for your Medicaid planner.

7 Large or unusual deposits and withdrawals [5]

NOTICE An amount coming in or going out that stands apart from the account's usual pattern.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount as shown, the account, and who might remember what it was. Don't decide why.

8 Transfers, gifts and checks to family

NOTICE Money moved between accounts, a check to a relative, a gift, something sold or signed over.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount as shown and where it went, if you know. Mark it as a question to go through with your Medicaid planner before anything is submitted, and don't change anything on your own.

9 The names on the account

NOTICE Exactly whose names are printed at the top of each statement: Mom alone, or Mom and someone else.

WRITE DOWN The names as printed. If the statement doesn't say what kind of account it is, ask the bank.

10 Accounts with no current paper [3]

NOTICE An account, a policy or a property that shows up on a tax return or an old statement but has no recent paper in the pile.

WRITE DOWN What it was, where you saw it, and the date of the paper you saw it on.

Among her other papers

11 The house and other real estate [5]

NOTICE The deed, the current property tax bill, any mortgage or home equity loan statement, and an appraisal if there is one.

WRITE DOWN Which of these you have, the names printed on each, and where they are kept.

12 Trust and annuity papers [6]

NOTICE A trust document, an annuity contract, or statements from either, if Mom has one.

WRITE DOWN What the paper is called, its date, the company or person named on it, and where it is. Don't read meaning into it; bring it.

13 Identity and residency papers [7] [4]

NOTICE Her Social Security card, birth certificate, proof of citizenship or immigration status, marriage certificate, and something that shows where she lives.

WRITE DOWN Which you have, and where each one is.

From the facility and the family

14 Paper and conversations at the rehab or facility

NOTICE Admission papers, bills, and anything the social worker or the business office hands you or says about Medicaid.

WRITE DOWN The date, who gave it or said it, and what it was, in their words. Note the admission date as the papers show it.

15 What has already been sent, and by whom

NOTICE An application or documents that Mom, a relative or someone at the facility may already have sent, and anything that came back to confirm it.

WRITE DOWN What was sent, the date, how, by whom, and where the copy and the confirmation are. Mark it "said, not confirmed" where you only have someone's word.

> **When a note isn't enough**
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> Some things on this list need a person as well as a note. A letter from the Medicaid agency that asks for something goes to your Medicaid planner, or to the office that sent it, along with your note of what it says; what it means and when a reply is due aren't things to work out alone. Deposits, withdrawals, gifts or transfers nobody can explain go to your Medicaid planner as questions before the application is submitted, without anyone deciding first what they mean. And a question about who has the authority to act or sign for Mom is a legal one, for an elder law attorney.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, whether anything counts for Medicaid, when a reply is due or whether Mom may qualify for anything. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. The professionals answer those questions, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You've gone through the pile and marked what stood out. The planning interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
4. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid

6. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care
7. USA.gov, How to apply for Medicaid and CHIP
